



ject is the National Policy on Relief and Rehabilitation being debated at the Group of Ministers (GoM) level. It was Sonia who pushed for this in response to the agitation against Narmada Dam projects in March. The Commerce Ministry too got a missive recently, asking it to look after the needs of small-scale leather manufacturers.

The leader is shedding the aura of the inaccessible. She has already dropped her ice-maiden demeanour that chilled some of her colleagues once. Nowadays, she encourages people to linger after formal UPA dinners, occasionally stops for coffee and gossip in Central Hall and even laughs at innocuous SMS jokes shown to her. Her bete noire Sushma Swaraj was pleasantly surprised when Sonia, having overheard her speaking Kannada to some Karnataka MPs in Parliament,

nudged her saying, "You learnt to speak Kannada because of me". (In 1998, Sushma had contested the Bellary polls against Sonia). Then Sonia had fumed at the campaign against her. Now she has learnt to take it in her stride.

Sonia is no longer the power that is felt but not seen—the invisible Madonna of 10 Janpath. She now leads from the front and has mastered the rules of running a coalition government, something which neither Rajiv nor Indira had to deal with. Recently, when a cabinet minister suggested that just as the Left had given the Congress grief over its candidate for President, so should

#### **THE UNCHALLENGED: Sonia's control over the party is absolute**

Sonia reject at least three names suggested by the comrades for vice-president, she laughed and said that she was not in favour of a tit-for-tat policy while dealing with the allies. Unlike her mother-in-law who ruled by diktats, Sonia prefers to give the impression of ruling by consensus.

The Congress chief masterminded the entire presidential campaign and even looked outside UPA, emerging from her fortress to dine with the tempestuous czarina of the heartland. After two lingering cups of coffee, Mayawati told her colleagues that she was "charmed" by Sonia. And the BSP support for any Congress candidate was sealed. Contrary to popular perception, while Shivraj Patil was Sonia's first choice, she already had the fallback option of Pratibha in place. The entire meeting at Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's residence which came up with Pratibha's name was choreographed in advance. Since Pratibha had mentioned a rapport with CPI general secretary A.B. Bardhan, he was the first to be sounded out. According to a Congress Working Committee member, Bardhan agreed to bring up the idea of a woman candidate but he wanted the Congress to suggest Pratibha's name. This task was delegated to the prime minister. Once the name was out in the open, Bardhan supported it. All Sonia did was to beam at the end of the meeting and pronounce it as a "historic occasion". And so it was in more ways than one.

As UPA chairperson, Sonia has kept the portfolio of allies management to herself. This includes master players like RJD President Lalu Prasad and NCP

chief Sharad Pawar. Her favourite, however, is Lalu. She hasn't forgotten that when BJP was targeting her foreign origin, it was Lalu who was her chief supporter. "During Indira Gandhi's time, there was only one dynasty. Now there are 50 dynasties and yet Sonia has ensured that the Nehru-Gandhi name remains the most rele-

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